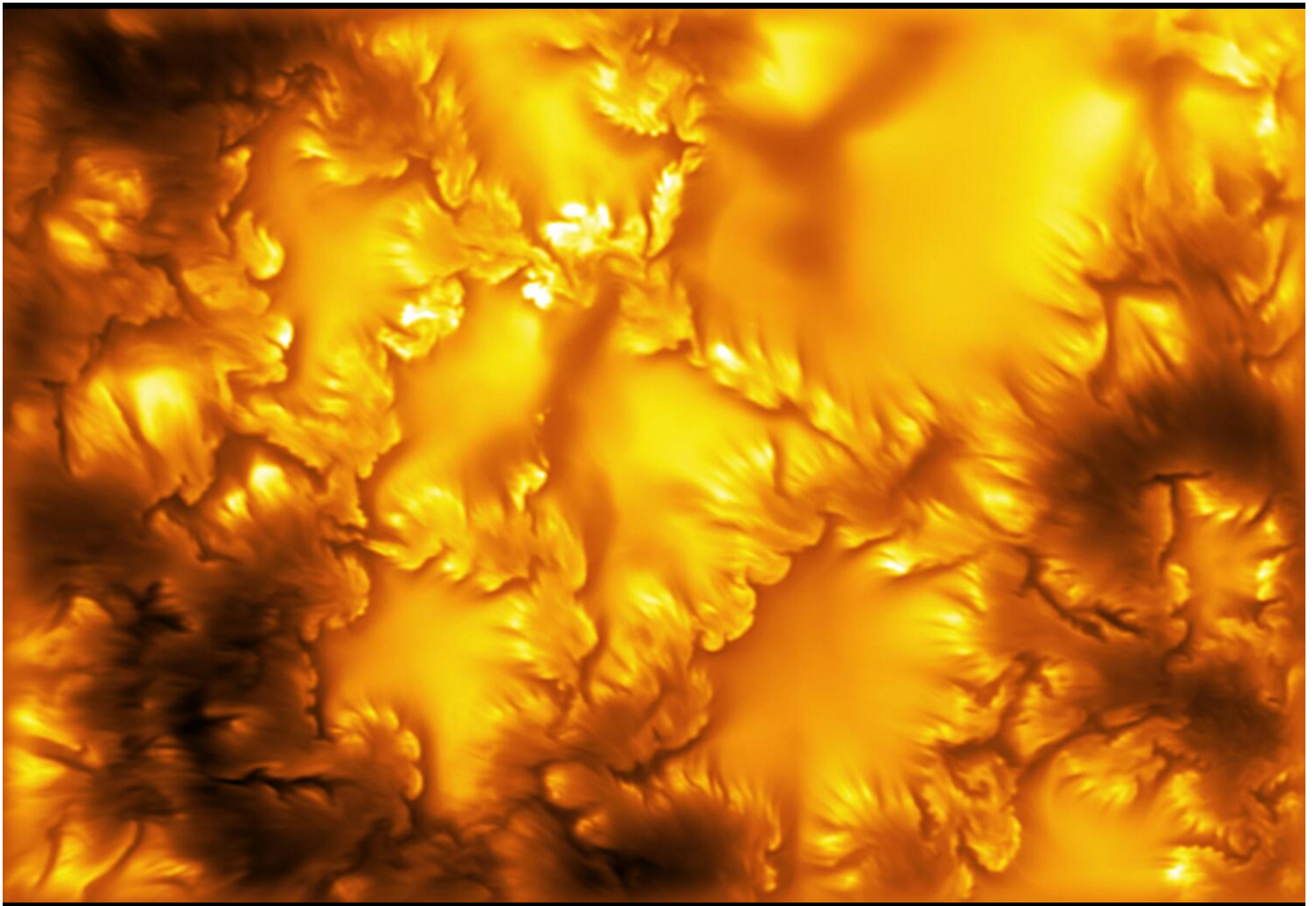


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 12

Another Kind of Freedom ~ The Sacred Potential of a Moment
23 August 2026



The highest-resolution image of the sun's surface ever captured NSF / NSO / AURA / MPS

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Fantasia and Fugue in C minor, BWV 537 – Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)

Let Us Break Bread Together – Chelsea Chen (b. 1983)

Méditation – Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Sonata No. 2 in D major – Elisabetta de Gambarini (1731–1765)

Transformations: Fantasia on “Pange Lingua” – Jessica French (b. 1984)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Megan Mascena & Rev. Tanaka Pack

We live our lives with little regard
for the import of each moment.
They come to us
in regular and rapid succession,
and we live through each of them into the next.
A simple, ongoing process
into which our lives are set at birth
and through which we will proceed unto our deaths.

Yet in each moment resides incredible power –
new life,
healing,
opportunity,
and we, who stumble through them
look to one another as we gather,
that we may do together
the work of opening one another
to the mysteries of this life,
and our potential of living to the fullest.

*Today, may our singing be filled with transformation,
may our words reflect the yearning of our hearts,
and may the Spirit of Life that builds within us as we gather,
hallow each and every passing moment
we know here together.*

[adapt/gv/lvf]

In expectation of what shall be,
we ask all of this.
Amen and Amen!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Listen, Now We Tell a Mystery

BEECHER

Listen, now we tell a mystery, told by prophets long before;
We will all be changed forever; pain and death will be no more.
With the Spirit's healing power faith becomes reality;
We proclaim immortal glory far beyond what we can see.

Sound the transformation trumpet; sing a song of victory;
Heaven and earth join in the chorus, welcoming new liberty.
Ever changing, ever growing, we claim all we're meant to be,
Joining in the Spirit's work of setting all creation free.

Celebrate new life eternal, springing from Creative Love;
Resurrection brings rejoicing all around us and above.
With the liberating Spirit, we will soar on angel wings,
Ever onward, ever forward, as the world in triumph rings.
-Lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

O Great life-giving Spirit,
whose voice we hear in the winds,
and whose warm breath gives life to all the world –
hear us humans on planet earth.

*Help us to remember
we are a part of the universe,
as natural and necessary as the rocks,
trees, and birds,
perhaps no more important, nor any less.*

Let us walk in beauty, Spirit of Life,
let our spirits see the dynamic quality of life in all that exists
with no prejudice or malice toward any creation.
May we begin to remember who we are in the natural order of life
as we stand in our own shallow pools of time.

*May we come to know, O Spirit,
what time it is
in our lives and in all life.
Amen.*

[adapt/fpeavey]

***Introit**

Good Trouble
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

THOMAS KEESECKER

This day has challenged us to make good trouble to make this world a better place.

***The Lord's Prayer**

Megan Mascena

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from 1 Kings*

Megan Mascena

This is the witness of the ancients...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

That truth has been inscribed into my heart
and into the heart of every human being,
there to be read and revered,
thanks be to you, O God.

That there are ways of seeing and sensitivities of knowing
hidden deep in the palace of the soul,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free,
thanks be to you.

Open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls
and be changed for the healing of the world,
*that we may listen for truth in every living soul
and be changed for the well-being of the world.*
Amen and Amen.

-J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

Meditation Anthem

I Flow, I Am
Laude

MARI ESABEL VALVERDE
TEXT: RAINER MARIA RILKE

And if the world has ceased to hear you, say to the silent earth: I flow. To the rushing water speak: I am.

Sermon

The Sacred Potential of a Moment

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Holiest Mystery,
Community of Love,
Creator, Christ, Spirit,
Three in One,
you in Christ,
Christ in us,
and everywhere, Spirit,
connecting, caressing, cajoling us into the
image of wholeness tattooed on the heart and
the soul of every living thing.

We are not alone,
never isolated except in the imagination of
our wounded hearts.

The Christ abides in us,
and we in they,
and the joy of this is why we sing,
and why we pray,
and why we take our place
in this joyous communion, saying:

*Thank you for this banquet of love,
this feast of joy,
this miracle of common purpose
through the Christ who taught us,
with goodness and grace.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Megan Mascena

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Wade in de Water TRADITIONAL AFRICAN-AMERICAN SPIRITUAL
Brandon Harris, Soloist, Dr. Emma Whitten, Piano arr. H.T. BURLEIGH

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Megan Mascena

For all that has been and for all that will be,
we give you our thanks, O God.

May these gifts be used to nurture the life
around us and among us,
as our lives grow
by the generosity of our hands,
and our hearts.

May it ever be so.
Amen and amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Truly, we live with mysteries too marvelous
to be understood.

How grass can be nourishing in the
mouths of lambs.
How rivers and stones are forever
in allegiance with gravity
while we ourselves dream of rising.
How two hands touch and the bonds
will never be broken.
How people come, from delight or the
scars of damage,
to the comfort of a poem.

Let me keep my distance, always, from those
who think they have the answers.

Let me keep company always with those who say
'Look!' and laugh in astonishment,
and bow their heads.

-Mary Oliver

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

Every Time I Feel the Spirit
Scott Graff, *Soloist*

TRADITIONAL SPIRITUAL
arr. WILLIAM DAWSON

*Hymn for the Journey

How Deep the Silence of the Soul

KINGSFOLD

How deep the silence of the soul that lives within your grace.
How full the gratitude of heart in your abiding place.
What rich serenity is found, what courage and release
when Wisdom teaches us to seek the gentle path to peace.

Like unseen chimes on moving air, like warm and morning sun,
Like glad-denying, green-ing, grow-ing things, like trees with blooms begun.
Such is your presence in our lives, you touch without a trace,
until we turn and find ourselves held fast in your embrace.

-Lyrics by Sylvia Dunstan

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Lucis creator – Dorothy Papadakos (b. 1960)

Inside The Music

"The sacred potential of a moment. I could think of no better summoning for the day than the call to action offered to us by the late Congressman John Lewis, stalwart champion of the civil rights movement. *"Get into good trouble. Necessary trouble"*—was his imperative rallying cry. The encouragement for moral courage, persistence, and perseverance for each of us to do our part in insisting on the dignity of all. In the choral introit, we recognize that THIS day has *challenged us to make good trouble...to make this world a better place*. The sacred potential of a moment, indeed.

We then move to Mari Esabel Valverde's musical meditation on Rilke's evocative poem, *I Flow: I Am*. In moments of challenge and discord—I am. In moments of personal suffering and community despair—I am. "*And if the world has ceased to hear you, say to the silent earth: I flow. To the rushing water speak: I am.*" Echoing Elijah's experience of God in the silence: when stirred to this sacred moment—we are.

Brandon and Dr. Whitten then offer us the rich history of *Wade in the Water*, traditional African-American spiritual arranged by H.T. Burleigh: a song used as a coded escape map for the enslaved of this country as they sought to help one another to deliverance. *God's gonna trouble the water*: code talk amongst the enslaved to step off dry land and into the rivers whose waters kept the bloodhounds of slave owners off the scent and trail, the history of which comes from God *troubling the waters* of the Jordan River and the Pool of Bethesda which led to the healing and freedom of the people. And in choral response to this spirit of urgency, every time we feel it moving in our souls, for its sacred potential in any given moment: we pray." ~ *Dr. Ianthi Marini*

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